

Exquisite Stillness

exquisite—extremely beautiful and delicate. highly sensitive and discriminating.

My father is a very fearful man. Of course, he would never admit it. But his fear has eroded a deeply grooved path in his being. Like water which runs through a canyon, my father has no choice but to follow the course that fear has carved through the terrain of his inner person.

My father has never learned that he is not exactly like his thoughts. He is completely identified with every thought and emotion that he experiences. That's why he is so easily offended. If his thoughts or emotions are challenged he has no choice but to become defensive and angry.

My father suffers deeply. But he has hidden his suffering so well from himself that he cannot understand why he feels the way he does. Because he cannot ease his own suffering he must blame people and circumstances for the way he feels.

Just last year I asked my father to come and help me. I was going through a difficult time with a recent divorce. I was going through a break-up. My kids weren't speaking to me. I was plagued by suicidal thoughts. My father was very helpful. He helped me to make the home where I was staying livable. When I asked him for money that he didn't have, he became very angry, telling me, "You are the reason that I am a bitter old man." His eyes were red and tearful and full of rage as he pointed his finger at me from across the table. Although I was also suffering, I was able to ask him to forgive me for the pain that I had caused him.

My father does not have friends. He told me that he has intentionally pushed people out of his life and that he experiences satisfaction when his birthday passes and no one acknowledges him. He has also told me that he is hurt when no one acknowledges his birthday. He has said both things to me. I think I understand how both can exist in separate moments.

It is difficult for me to relate to my father. I know that if I challenge his thoughts and emotions there will be conflict. It seems that merely presenting my own experience challenges him, so I often just let him talk and talk about the way he sees the world, knowing that it will be easier if I just stay quiet.

I am beginning to see how I too, have lived in fear. I am beginning to see how my suffering has injured others. I am beginning to learn how to give myself the compassion needed to allow my fearful thoughts and emotions to dissolve. I am beginning to stop blaming people and circumstances for my own suffering.

When I was four years old I watched the movie Jaws. The ocean, I understood, is where fear resides. But that's not really how it is. Fear resides in my own mind. The ocean is just the ocean and sharks are just sharks. I understand now that there is some remote possibility that if I go into the ocean that a shark might eat me. But if I allow my fear to dictate where I go and what I do, then I may never go into the ocean and play in the waves.

When my children were young, we took them to the ocean for kayaking. I and my oldest daughter, Anna, became seasick. Our guide, Max, suggested that we jump in the cool water to relieve our nausea. I felt sure that as soon as I jumped in the ocean that I would be eaten by a shark, but I jumped in anyway, and so did my daughter. I did not want to pass on my fear to her.

This weekend I went on a solo backpacking adventure in the Pecos Wilderness of New Mexico. As I was signing the trail register, I noticed someone had written a warning about cougars. "Stay together!" they wrote. I was by myself. There was no one to stay together *with*.

As I set out on the trail I felt like prey, scanning the mountain above and below for movements of large cats.

After seven exhausting hours on the trail, I pitched my tent, made myself dinner, and built a large fire. The crackling warmth of the flames made me feel safe and secure. It was the first time I had ever been in the wilderness all by myself. I went to sleep watching the campfire from the tent. Two hours later I awoke suddenly. The fire was out. It was dark. There was a mysterious clicking sound close to my camp. I was terrified.

I lay there for some time, hoping that I could fall back to sleep, but I could not. I finally sat up in the tent as straight as I could. I listened to the strange clicking sound. A light rain began to fall on my small tent. The sound of the raindrops hitting the tent just inches from my head was unpleasant. I startled with fear when the logs in the fire shifted suddenly. My brain started inventing other reasons to be fearful, but panic was not an option. I was miles from anyone or anywhere. No cell reception. No help. no comfort.

I recalled my meditative practice and I calmly prayed. I focused my attention on my breath. I realized that no matter how unpleasant the sound of the rain was, I could not change that. I accepted that I was vulnerable and alone in a dark forest with only a thin layer of fabric between me and the wild. I had no control over any of this. The only thing I had any chance to control was my response to fear.

Eventually the rain stopped. I recalled something I had read earlier that day from Pema Chodron. She had encouraged me to move toward my difficulties instead of trying to push them away. I wondered, "What if I get out of this tent and just sit outside in the dark?" I allowed myself some room to make friends with this idea. Part of me was resistant, but another part of me thought that that might be okay. Minutes passed. As I opened the tent, the sound of the zipper seemed to echo throughout the canyon. I found my sandals and then I sat again, waiting for the courage to go out into the dark, closer to whatever threats, real or imagined, might await me. As I finally emerged I could see the outlines of large rocks and trees. I sat on a large stone by the extinguished campfire. I could still feel some warmth emanating from the darkened coals.

As I stared into the night forest, I allowed myself to become aware of my breathing. Thoughts came and went. I imagined a sudden piercing howl. I imagined that Golem was creeping around on the rocks just outside my camp. I imagined that a large cougar was stalking me, skulking down the mountain in preparation to attack. But, every time a thought came I allowed myself to return to the stillness that was all around me. I told myself, "none of these imaginations are actually happening." What *was* happening in my surroundings was stillness. The mysterious clicking had stopped. The rain had ceased. There was absolutely no wind. I was in the middle of a profoundly still forest. Exquisite stillness.

When I allowed the stillness between my thoughts to align with the stillness of the Pecos Wilderness there was harmony. Stillness within. Stillness without. As the fears came I understood that I had a choice. I could allow my mind to entertain fear, but then I would be missing what was *really* going on. So I just kept coming back to the stillness, and when I did that, there *was* no fear. I had no control over what *might* happen in the next moment. But that was really none of my business. I was much more concerned with what was *actually* happening, this Exquisite Stillness. I was eventually able to return to my sleeping bag. I slept until the sun rose.

Hiking down the mountain is often much easier than hiking up. Me and my son Joseph have hiked together a number of times. He likes to consider all that potential energy that we store up in our bodies as we are hiking up the mountain which is now being converted into kinetic energy as we make our way down.

Still sensing the release of this kinetic energy as I drove home from my solo backpack adventure, I called my father. I wanted to talk to him about how I had felt in my role as potential cougar food, because I knew he'd understand. He loves to think about the terrors of being eaten alive. Our conversation was the impetus for the words you are now reading.

I have lived for most of my adult life powerless to control how I respond to fear. My fears were so deeply imbedded that I didn't even understand that they *were* fears. I participated in psychotherapy; I joined churches; I prayed; I had demons cast out of me; I went to AA meetings; I exercised; I studied; I tried to be a loving person; I became an atheist; I meditated; I became a feminist; I had intelligent and caring friends; I listened to my wife; I went back to school and got a better job; I played music; I got standing ovations; I did so many things to try to fix myself, but fear continued to dictate how I perceived the world. Even when the forest was still, my brain was inventing fears.

I want to be careful here that I don't sound like I have the answer, but if I am truthful, I feel like I do. I will try to explain. Today the answer for me is acceptance of what-is, and confidence that a power greater than myself is able and willing to restore me to sanity. When I am in the dark forest all by myself and my brain is inventing a half dozen reasons that I should be scared, I now know that I am not obligated to follow these story lines. If I am willing to look inward toward that Exquisite Stillness, I can experience a profound shift in my inward attitude, a miracle of perception change. Today I am willing to experience a deeper Reality than I was able to conjure for myself. If I allow it, this deeper Reality will flow from within me. A well has been unstopped that I had allowed to be clogged by my fearful suffering.

All of those things I said about my father, those things are true about me too, *if* I choose that reality. And *if* that is the reality that I choose, I render myself powerless, bound to my fearful story lines.

No matter how hard I tried, I could not think myself out of my inherited mental illness. But today something has changed. Today I have a reprieve from my insanity. Today I am focused on this Exquisite Stillness.